THE CASE FOR BOOSTERS

The milder disease Omicron variants cause and doubt that older vaccines may not work for newer strains has led many to forgo the booster despite rising Covid numbers. Yet experts insist it's our best bet

By Sonali Acharjee

Complacency has been as much of an obstacle in our fight against Covid as the virus itself. First, it was pandemic fatigue that made people shed mask and social distancing protocols, then it was vaccine hesitancy, now it's both. The seemingly milder Omicron variant and sub-variants, as well as the fortification of two doses, and possibly a booster dose, of the Covid vaccine has lulled people into believing that Covid is behind them. But if there's one thing the virus has taught us—and brutally in the case of Delta—it is not to take it for granted.

Indeed, India is seeing a rise in Covid cases again, as the country reported a 45 per cent single-day rise in new cases with 17,073 fresh infections on June 27. In the week ending June 26, India recorded 100,000 new cases and 100 deaths, the highest in three months. Kerala and Maharashtra, which seem to be leading this surge, have well over 20,000 active cases each. Delhi, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu remain other states of concern. Delhi is seeing a sustained increase, with daily cases crossing the 1,000-mark since June 14. The capital also had a high positivity rate of 7.8 per cent as on June 27.

AIIMS chief Dr Randeep Guleria is categorical when he says, "Covid is still very much around and non-adherence to Covid-appropriate behaviour as well as a low uptake of booster doses have contributed to the spread. We need to revert to mask usage, adopting one as a second skin."

What concerns experts is the unrestricted spread of the virus, and the possibility that it may spawn a more contagious, and possibly deadlier, mutation. Of the five major variants—Alpha, Beta, Gamma, Delta and Omi-